

Personalization Willingness-to-Pay Study

Conjoint study of Gen Z and millennial appetite for personalized athletic products

Prepared by Brightline Panel Research for a commissioning client

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Internal - limited distribution

Fictional data created for the MarketSignal demo.

1. Objectives

This study was commissioned to answer a practical question for athletic apparel and footwear brands: how much more are younger consumers willing to pay for products that are personalized to them, and which kinds of personalization carry the most value? The question matters because personalization usually brings higher unit costs, longer lead times and more operational complexity, so a premium has to be both achievable and large enough to cover them.

The brief was deliberately narrow. The study covers footwear, with running shoes as the reference product, and does not attempt to estimate demand for personalized apparel or accessories. It measures stated willingness to pay at a point in time and does not model supply side costs, which the commissioning team will assess separately. Findings are intended to inform a decision on whether to test a paid personalization tier and, if so, at what price.

We set four objectives. First, to measure the share of consumers who would accept given price premiums for personalized footwear. Second, to compare the value of different kinds of personalization, including fit, colorway and name or initials. Third, to compare Gen Z with older cohorts. Fourth, to describe the limits of what a survey based design can say about real purchasing behavior.

2. Method

The study surveyed 2,400 US consumers aged 16 to 40 in March 2026, including 1,350 Gen Z respondents. Respondents were drawn from an online panel, screened for at least one athletic footwear purchase in the prior year, and quota sampled on age, gender and region. Within the total, 1,350 were classified as Gen Z, roughly 780 as millennials, and the remainder fell into older or younger edge groups that are not analyzed here. Fieldwork took about eleven minutes per respondent.

Quality controls included attention checks, a minimum completion time, removal of respondents who selected the no purchase option on every task, and a check for inconsistent answers between the conjoint and the direct question. About one in twelve completes was removed under these rules before analysis. Results for the Gen Z and millennial groups are reported with margins of error of roughly plus or minus three points; for any smaller sub group, the margin is wider and we flag it where it applies.

The core of the questionnaire was a choice based conjoint exercise. Each respondent saw eight screens, each showing three configurations of a running shoe and a no purchase option.

Configurations varied on five attributes: personalization of fit, personalization of colorway, name or initials, delivery time, and price. Price varied from the base level up to a premium of 25% in five steps. Utilities were estimated using hierarchical Bayesian models and converted into the share of respondents who would accept a given premium for a given feature.

The conjoint was supplemented by a direct question, asked after the choice tasks, that asked each respondent whether they would pay a stated premium for a shoe personalized to their fit. Direct and conjoint estimates were consistent within a few points, which gives us confidence in the internal validity of the design. Both are, however, stated measures, a point we return to in Section 6.

3. Headline findings

38% of Gen Z respondents said they would pay a 15% premium for footwear personalized to their fit. The share is meaningful, and it shows that fit personalization is the form of customization that most Gen Z respondents can see themselves paying for.

Stated willingness to pay drops steeply above a 15% premium, with only 12% of Gen Z respondents accepting a 25% premium. The curve is steep because acceptance depends on the premium relative to perceived value. At modest premiums, a majority of respondents were willing to pay. Beyond a point, the offer is treated as a luxury, and respondents shift either to the standard product or to a lower priced alternative.

Respondents valued personalized fit about three times more than personalized colorways in the conjoint exercise. Utility scores for fit were consistently higher than for any other attribute in every cohort, a result that held for both men and women and in every region. Name and initials contributed the least, and respondents who rated them highly in the direct question often chose standard options in the conjoint tasks.

4. Segment cuts

Among millennial respondents, 29% said they would pay a 15% premium for footwear personalized to their fit. The gap between cohorts is meaningful and is consistent with other findings on greater openness to new product formats among younger buyers. It is also consistent with the lower incomes and greater price sensitivity of many Gen Z households, which keeps absolute willingness to pay modest.

Geography played a smaller role than age. Respondents in the West and Northeast were slightly more willing to pay than those in the Midwest and Southwest, but differences were within the margin of error for most price points. Purchase frequency was a better predictor: respondents who buy footwear more than twice a year accepted a 15% fit premium at a rate noticeably above the cohort average, and respondents who buy once a year or less accepted it at a rate noticeably below.

Only 21% of Gen Z respondents would pay a 15% premium for personalized colorways alone. Color options are widely appreciated, and respondents described them as enjoyable, but they rarely supported a premium on their own. When color was combined with a fit feature, the combined offer was valued more than either feature separately, though the fit feature contributed most of the premium.

Within Gen Z, willingness to pay was highest among respondents who train regularly and among those who buy footwear four or more times a year. It was lowest among those who described themselves as price led shoppers. Women in the cohort showed slightly higher acceptance of a fit premium than men, a difference that was not statistically significant at the 95% level.

5. Which attributes matter

Relative importance scores, which show how much each attribute moved choice across the levels tested, were as follows: personalized fit 45%, material and construction 18%, personalized colorway 15%, delivery time 15% and name or initials 7%. The ranking is stable across cohorts, though the weight on delivery time rose among Gen Z respondents who buy through social platforms.

Two points follow. First, fit personalization is worth about three times the value of colorway alone, and it is the only form that supports a premium beyond the low single digits. Second, delivery time is a meaningful negative: a longer wait reduced acceptance of a premium at every price level, which suggests that the operational promise matters as much as the product feature.

A related result concerns material and construction. Respondents placed it second in importance, ahead of colorway, which implies that personalization is more likely to be valued when it is attached to a product they already regard as well made. Several respondents wrote in comments that they would not pay extra to personalize a shoe that they expected to wear out quickly, which echoes a theme in other consumer research on knit uppers and early wear.

5.1 Price thresholds

The table below shows the share of respondents accepting each premium for footwear personalized to their fit. Acceptance falls at every step, with the steepest drop between 15% and 25%.

Premium over base price | Gen Z accepting | Millennials accepting

5%	61%	52%
10%	49%	40%
15%	38%	29%
20%	24%	18%
25%	12%	8%

A premium of around 10% is the level at which close to half of Gen Z accepts. A premium of 15% is the level at which acceptance falls below two in five. Doubling the price increase from 10% to 20% roughly halves acceptance.

6. Stated versus revealed preference

All of the figures in this report are stated preferences. They record what respondents say they would do when presented with hypothetical choices, and they are known to overstate real purchase behavior. Respondents tend to be generous toward a feature they find appealing, do not pay a price in the survey, and cannot fully anticipate the friction involved in a real purchase, such as a wait for delivery, a scan appointment or a final sale policy.

In similar studies, the gap between stated acceptance and observed uptake has been substantial, and the gap tends to be largest for features that are attractive but not essential. We therefore recommend that readers treat the percentages as a ceiling and as a way to rank options, not as a forecast of sales. A pilot with real prices and real orders is the best way to calibrate the gap for a specific brand and product.

When a pilot is run, we suggest tracking at least four measures: the share of shoppers who choose the paid tier, the repeat purchase rate compared with a matched control group, the return rate, and the share who abandon because of lead time. Together these show whether personalization adds value after the novelty fades, which a survey cannot establish.

Other caveats apply. The panel excludes consumers who do not take surveys online, the conjoint presents a limited set of attributes, and respondents saw price in a context that made premiums salient. The study was fielded in March 2026, and shifts in consumer confidence since then could affect the results.

7. Implications for brands

- Lead with fit. Personalization that improves fit is the only form with demonstrated pull at a meaningful premium; colorway and initials work better as low cost or free engagement features.
- Price in the range that the data supports. A premium near 10% is accepted by roughly half of Gen Z, whereas the share falls quickly beyond 15%.
- Protect delivery speed. A long lead time offsets the value of personalization, so the operating model must be able to deliver quickly.
- Segment the offer. Millennials accept lower premiums, and price led Gen Z shoppers will not pay one, so a tiered offer with a free base option is safer than a single premium product.
- Test with real customers before scaling. Use a pilot to measure uptake, repeat purchase and returns against a control group, and compare the results with the stated figures in this report.

Pricing architecture deserves attention. A structure with a free or low cost entry option, a mid tier at a modest premium, and a higher tier for full fit personalization allows brands to capture shoppers across the price curve without forcing a single decision. The study did not test tiering directly, and brands should validate it, but the shape of the acceptance curve suggests that most of the revenue opportunity lies at or below the 15% level.

8. Conclusion

Younger consumers say they value personalization, and a sizeable minority say they would pay for it, but only when it solves a real problem and when the premium is modest. Fit is the feature that matters. The size of the premium that can be charged is narrower than enthusiasm for the idea might suggest, and the survey evidence is best used to set hypotheses for testing in the market. We would be glad to discuss the underlying data tables with the commissioning team.